

The King of Ritual Manuals Called 'Traversing the Three by Vajra'

Vajrabhūmitricaraṇarājakaḷpa nāma · Toh 500 · Derge Kangyur

ར་དོ་སྤྱི་གསུམ་དུ་བྱ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའི་རིམ་པའི་རིམ་པ་

Toh 500 in the Kangyur is a tantric ritual text known in English as "The King of Ritual Manuals Called 'Traversing the Three by Vajra,'" corresponding to the Sanskrit Vajrabhūmitricaraṇarājakaḥ and the Tibetan Rdo rjes gsum du rgyu ba zhes bya ba'i rtoḡ pa'i rgyal po. It belongs to the class of kalpa or ritual manual literature associated with Vajrayāna practice, concerning the use of deity, mantra, and meditative practice as a path in which conceptuality is overcome through conceptuality itself, ultimately leading to the peace of the wrathful deity realization. The text is presented as a teaching proclaimed by the Lord of Secrets in connection with Śākyamuni of the wrathful family, and it includes detailed instructions on the formation of seed syllables and their embellishments, situating it firmly within the esoteric tantric corpus of the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Vajrabhūmitricaraṇarājakaḷpa nāma. In the language of Tibet: The King of Ritual Manuals Called "Traversing the Three by Vajra."

Homage to the glorious vajra ḍākinī.

Then the Lord of Secrets, Śākyamuni of the wrathful family, proclaimed this supreme manual of ritual, which conquers subsequent conceptuality. Through deity, mantra, and practice, it is the path that destroys conceptuality by conceptuality; through awareness beyond conceptuality, the Lord of Wrathful Ones attained peace.

First is the homage; below that, the fourth syllable adorns the fifth with the third vowel sign. The third of the sixth is taken up, and below it is adorned with the second vowel. Upon that are the half-moon and the dot. The fourth of the fifth, and likewise the second of the sixth, and the fourth of the fourth as well. Then again the seed-syllable of fire, then the third of the fifth, and below the third of the second is the seed-syllable of fire. The first of the fifth as well, and the fifth division of the third, adorned with the third vowel. After that, Vajrasattva, the essence of Vajrapāṇi: the first of the fifth, and the first of the third placed at the end. These are the mantras of awareness that summon the wrathful buddhas possessing the awakening mind, together with spirits, in a number equal to the grains of sand in ten Ganges rivers.

The mantras of awareness are themselves the deity. This deity, a mingling of emptiness and compassion, should be contemplated as properly established in the practice within the heart. These mantras, forward and reversed, should be recited and written.

PHAṬ HŪṢ NI PĀ DZRA VA RADHA RA VĀLĀṢ NĪ OM

Through reciting the mantras of awareness a hundred thousand times, reciting each syllable a hundred thousand times, and through the practice beyond even that, the practitioner's intentions are accomplished in due order through the practice of placing it in the heart — whether pacification, enrichment, magnetizing and drawing in, dispelling, separating, banishing, or slaying, or whatever activity is desired.

One who has a pure body and possesses compassion, with making prostrations to one's body as the deity and to the guru as a preliminary, should meditate on the wrathful one of awareness. First, contemplate emptiness fully; then cleanse the defilements of embodied beings. In one's own heart, from the first vowel arises the moon disk, upon which one visualizes the blue syllable HŪṢ. Rays of light emanate from one's samādhi-form, purifying the defilements of sentient beings; they are gathered back and absorbed into the essence of the form. The HŪṢ in turn becomes a blue vajra; as before, emanating and gathering, it becomes a vast blazing blue form — supremely proud and wrathful, possessing eight-times-two aspects of terrifying appearance, endowed with a fierce and wrathful expression. Adorned on the body with eight serpents, with one face and two hands: the right hand holds the vajra, gripping it in a threatening gesture; the left hand, with pointing finger extended in warning, holds a blue lower garment as a skirt. The eyes are red and the teeth gnash; the hair is like the rays of the sun, bound up above, crowned with a diadem at the center. From the mouth sounds the laughter of "HĀ HĀ." This lord of the wrathful ones inspires terror, destroying misleaders and the like.

Having well meditated on oneself as just such a one, then entering into the equanimity of that state, in his heart upon the sun disk, from one's own dharma syllables, rays are repeatedly emanated by the wrathful one; and one should meditate in union with that. Together with mantra and mudrā, empowerment is likewise received, and remaining in the samādhi of the Vajra-HŪṢ, one seizes upon malevolent sentient beings; through rays of variegated light that arise, one consumes plague, demons, poisons, and the

like.

This concludes the first contemplation from "The Vajra Moving Beneath."

Then, from the sense sources such as the eyes and so forth, one should meditate on the wrathful one arising from HŪM. For the three — body and the rest — one meditates on the three vajras. This meditation is what bestows empowerment.

First, through the peaceful approach, one brings peace. Having fashioned the form of nāgas and the like, one draws them in by light from one's own heart and dissolves them within. Through compassion, one gives the offering-fire. There is the Steadfast One, the One of Noble Lineage, the Lotus of Boundless Wealth, the Great Lotus Conch-Keeper, and the Cause of Power — through the application of compassion, one purifies the poisons. The black, white, and blue ones are to be applied each to their own proper domain. Alternatively, in a peaceful hearth, the misdeeds of nāgas are to be pacified. For those of the most intensely dark kind, one heals them with the three sweets and water. Any sinful one who cannot be tamed by peaceful means — through the combined application of both, one severs their stream.

Having accomplished the rites using blood, poison, and the like as substances, with mantras of reversal, one then employs the extremely wrathful one to hook, to drive in, to strike and kill with intoxication. Through the rite one subdues the malevolent and burns them and performs the other activities. At the times of the eighth and fourteenth, at the red flush of the eastern dawn, and at the moment when day and night are spent, with hair unbound and essence-fluid dripping, naked — one vomits blood at the dwelling place of animals. One accomplishes that with blazing fire at the center of the body. From the pores of the wrathful one's hairs, the emanated wrathful ones in their wrath — having been summoned and dispatched — are drawn forth, and by contemplation one devours contemplation. As formerly the vajra moves beneath, so here the malevolent ones are to be devoured. What need is there of speaking at great length?

For sentient beings who are untamed, Vajrasattva (Skt. vajrasattva) — he of compassionate mind — through the application of substances such as sesame and mantra, pacifies misdeeds and performs the fire offering. Samantabhadra, possessed of the wisdom of awareness, performs the elaborate fire offering into milk-curd. For trainees who have become unstable, through great bliss with a mind of attachment, in order to stabilize what one oneself requires, one

accomplishes this through red utpala lotus and the like.

Here, those who are perverse and commit misdeeds — primarily in order to purify them, with a wrathful mind through wrathful action — all that is taught in every tantra is to be done here. The awareness mantra moves by the force of compassion. Cutting the stream of bad karma is artificial. In the nature of purified bad karma, the wrathful one does not conceive of an object of anger — the applications become artificial. Awakening is without artifice, freed from effort.

This concludes the second contemplation from "The Vajra Moving Beneath the Ground."

Then, the Victorious One of the Three Realms (Skt. trailokyavijaya): formerly, through sixteen emanations, forty contemplations — here, through two, the awareness is destroyed. The condensation into eight emanations and the meditation on oneself as a single one are also taught.

In the space of the sky, one contemplates the four elements. From Mount Meru, from the syllable HRĪḤ, at the center of a lotus with a counted number of petals, there is a complete moon-maṇḍala. The wrathful one arisen from HŪṂ has one face, four arms, and is blue-black in color. He brandishes vajra, bell, arrow, and bow. He is adorned at the head with serpents and charnel-ground ornaments, his lower body bound with tiger-skin, and he dispels terror. One meditates on the wrathful Victorious One.

Through the application of the HŪṂ at his heart, in the directions and intermediate directions — east and the rest — the Vajra that Illuminates the Three Worlds, the Jewel that Tames the Three Worlds, the Lotus that Binds the Three Worlds, and that which Destroys the Three Worlds itself: those on the right bear their own names and marks, while those on the left menace with malevolence. Amṛtakunḍalin, the Blue Staff, Acalanātha, and Hayagrīva — the wrathful one: vajra, staff, sword, and lotus are those on the right. Those on the left menace with malevolence. In the center of these eight, I, the wrathful one, purify the confusion of the three worlds. The four messengers — the dark staff and the rest —

Adorned with bodily hue and marks, wrathful,
the hook and the rest stand at the gates.

Meditate upon the wrathful wheel that dispels fear.

All the wrathful ones of awareness — the chief and the rest —
wear a garland of intestines as a necklace,

are wrapped in a blue garment and a tiger-skin,
and are to be meditated upon as the path that dispels harm.

Then the chief of the Victorious Ones over the three realms (Skt. tridhātu) — the marks and mantra of the wrathful one — are explained. Homage to the Three Jewels.

Vajrapāṇi, the great lord of the yakṣa hosts, clad in blue, confirmed by buddhas as numerous as the grains of sand in the river Ganges: his fangs are clenched and his eyes are fitted with a mass resembling blazing fire, flames shooting from his breath like tongues of fire, his voice inspiring terror. His hands and feet are adorned with the progeny of Nāgarāja Kubera. He grasps a black nāga by the hair. The blazing nāgas Nandā and Upanandā serve as his earrings. He bears a crown of blazing precious jewels set with serpents. He devours ferociously venomous, blazing nāgas. His full face bears brows and wrathful furrows gathered at the brow. His upper teeth press down upon his lower lip. His tongue flickers like lightning, having the appearance of Yama, lord of death. Great of belly, he devours serpents. The sound of his clapping hands strikes terror. The nāga king Padmānābha is bound as his girdle. He roars "A-la-la!" His feet reach down to the ocean floor at a depth of eighty-four thousand leagues, rising up to the level of his knees; Indra (Śakra) and the sun he bears upon his shoulders. He utterly destroys all nāgas. With great, loud laughter he throws everything into turmoil. Having the form of Yama, he strikes terror into the three realms. Homage to him who utterly destroys all nāgas.

Then one is to recite this awareness mantra spoken by the Blessed One, the Buddha, in a number equal to the grains of sand in the river Ganges:

tadyathā — bho bho vanāgādhipataye, idānīm lāmbaradhara śarīraṃ, vajrapāṇi hṛdayaṃ yasmāt tikramatha mākulotsādana, bhaviṣyati — tadyathā: buddha buddha, vibuddha vibuddha, mahīprāpta hara hara nāgānāṃ chinda chinda, nāga hṛdayāni, bindha bindha nāga marmāṇi, viśīryantu nāga śarīrāṇi, visphoṭaya, nāga nayanāni hūṃ hūṃ phaṭ — tadyathā: nāgavidāraṇāya hūṃ phaṭ, nāgotsādanāya hūṃ phaṭ, nīlāmbasanāya hūṃ phaṭ, apratihatabalapara kramāya hūṃ phaṭ, kṛtāntāya hūṃ phaṭ, kṛtāntarūpāya hūṃ phaṭ, roṣaṇāya hūṃ phaṭ, trāsaṇāya hūṃ phaṭ, kumbhāṇḍotsādanāya hūṃ phaṭ, pretapiśāca vināśakarāya hūṃ phaṭ, yakṣāpasmāra vināśakarāya hūṃ phaṭ, hasa hasa, dhara dhara, māraya māraya, nāśaya nāśaya, sarva vighnān pinākakarāya

hūṃ phaṭ, sarva śatrūṃ saṃgha vināśakarāya hūṃ phaṭ — oṃ nīṃ
lāṃbaradhara vajrapāṇi rājñāpayati svāhā.

For the ritual application of this: one who has been seized by a yakṣa should have mantra-empowered water cast upon them and gtor ma offerings made, and they will be released.

For averting nāgas, one should use a bamboo switch or a switch of Himalayan rhododendron.

For hungry ghosts and those who cause forgetting, one should use a blue thread.

For eliminating epidemic disease and for those afflicted by written spells, one should use a blue thread.

If one desires wealth, one should observe a one-day fast and burn fragrant incense; then in dreams all matters of virtue and non-virtue will be shown, and seven thousand gold coins will be given.

If one wishes to break a seal, one should use ash.

If one wishes to open an iron door, one should use white mustard seed.

For protection against all fears, one should use old butter, or ash, or white mustard seed.

For protection against all dangers of illness, one should tie a protective knot on a blue thread and fasten it around the neck — it becomes the supreme protection.

For children threatened by spirits, a five-colored thread fastened around the neck becomes the supreme protection.

If one wishes to repel thieves, one should use soil.

For poison, one should apply kuśa grass.

For self-protection, one should use mind or water. For protecting others, one should use a blue thread. For all these rites, the mantra should be recited three times, or seven, or fourteen, or twenty-one, or one hundred and eight times. If done in this way, success will be achieved.

This is the third contemplation from "Moving Beneath the Vajra Earth."

These contemplations that govern —
from wrathful Vajrapāṇi —

through the yoga of swirling nectar,
the servants and attendants are to be roused.

Oṃ amṛta kuṇḍali hana hana hūṃ phaṭ.

This is proclaimed as a mere command.
The thirty-two syllables of the vai-letter are recited.
Through the light of the heart, one exercises lordship.
Fumigated with guggul incense, they are roused.

To the Great Golden-Nosed One riding a lion, to Mugdzin, to Gangwa Zang, to Norbu Zang, to Kubera, to Yangdak Shé, to Drokné, to Ngatsén, and to Picci Kuṇḍali — these are to be given what they require.

These ones who ride horses —
radiant and bearing mirrors —
are to be revealed upon pure white cloth,
and all their luminous appearances are to be drawn.

Or else all of them ride black serpents,
bearing fearsome weapons in their hands.
When the rousings are made pure and sovereign,
they will accomplish every wrathful act.

The nine fierce ones and the twenty-eight,
spreading throughout the three earths —
through the power of accomplished mantra, one makes them one's servants,
and at the proper times they are to be offered worship.

Then, for one who fears poverty,
the accomplishment of Mugdzin is joyfully described.
All press down upon the treasuries:
blazing jewels fill the house.
A full skull-cup will be accomplished through vajra water.

For the lotus, moon, and great treasury —
the nine yakṣas arising from Jam —
when summoned, each is offered
a fire oblation together with water, using their individual secret mantras.

These are the feet of the mantra.

Oṃ vaiśravaṇāya svāhā. Oṃ jaṃbhalāya svāhā. Oṃ pūrṇabhadrāya svāhā. Oṃ maṇibhadrāya svāhā. Oṃ kuberāya svāhā. Oṃ saṃprajñānāya svāhā. Oṃ guhyasthānāya svāhā. Oṃ pāñcikāya svāhā. Oṃ picikuṇḍaline svāhā.

Then, the supreme of authentic conduct,
the pure divine observances, are described.

At all times, pure silken blue garments are to be blessed and worn. Following the brahmin's custom, one should remain far from fragrant foods and swift-moving flesh. Dwelling in fasting, one should bathe with water, eat the pure three white foods, restrain the breath of speech, and, with devotion and compassion moistening the mind, engage in constant diligence.

The meditation house, its hue turned blue, is smeared with heavy-scented, sweet-smelling water. White and blue flowers are strewn about; a reliquary image of the lama (one's teacher) is placed before one. A pure celebrant of noble lineage, clothed in white, sits upon a kuśa grass seat. The sacred fierce mantras of compassion are to be recited cleanly and beautifully. A rosary of rudrākṣa beads, one hundred and fifty in number, is blessed and held in the right hand. Bead by bead, with each deity and each mantra together, one holds it at the heart. Thoroughly analyzing these yogas, with a mind devoted to beings, I have expounded these contemplations for the benefit of self and others.

This is the fourth contemplation from "Moving Beneath the Vajra Earth."

Like fire born from summer-grown grass and woodland kindling,
aided by the wind, it burns, and not even the ash that remains is left behind —
just so, the wounds of conceptual defilement born over immeasurable eons
are burned by the fire of pure mind through the recitation of mantras, guarded
by faith and diligence.

The essence of the sun, taking its lineage at the center of Jambudvīpa —
men and women whose faculties are unblemished and who hold moral discipline,
who carry the momentum of the path from former lives and have received the
lama's transmission —

endowed with the resolve to relinquish sentient beings' suffering through faith
and compassion —
such a one should meditate on the wrathful deity of awareness (vidyā), and
then apply diligence in recitation.

Through praise, offering, and worship, one satisfies the servant-spirits, the asuras, and the keepers of secrets without fail.

Striving at the water-offering circles and torma,
and satisfying the gods and servant-spirits through fire-offerings —
before long, that practitioner will draw forth the signs and the mudrās.

There is no need to say much more here.

The signs explained before, beneath the vajra earth,
shall be granted. Copper and iron are the lama's to bestow.

Having conferred the empowerment of awareness upon the body and so forth,
fire, wind, and the other elements,
illness, possessing spirits, curses,
and the māra shall find no opening.

If a death-conjunction of the kind described, arising from the perception of a chain of flames,
should appear — fling this stinginess aside,
rely on the leading-thread of aspiration,
and under this, the bodhisattva
shall become a lama who ripens beings.

Alternatively, abandoning the intermediate state of existence,
the practitioner enkindles the consciousness through mantra
and, having become a knowledge-holder who benefits beings,
becomes a bodhisattva thereafter.

At the very least, relying on the path
and obtaining a body agreeable to one's wishes,
clearing the former path and thereafter
fully abiding in the siddhis.

One who has realized deities, mantras, and the like
suppresses lower conceptual thought.
Conceptuality, non-conceptual like space,
having cast aside the world, displays through thought's own manifestation.

When disciples whose minds are stirred by aversion and the like arise,
I act with compassion even toward the hostile.
If anger and the like cannot be removed,
why then does one become wrathful?

First, the yogin vanquishes harm;
therefore the applications of awareness-mantra
are taught throughout all the tantras.

Having vanquished harm, purity arises —
a pure mind is bliss.

Because the harmful conjunction is seized away,
one joyfully treads the path to awakening.

The vajra body itself is unchanging;
the primordial wisdom of awareness —
that is the fruit for the embodied being.

Just as crystal appears otherwise
by the flower of the rose-apple tree,
so too does non-conceptual awareness
appear here as the lord of the wrathful ones,
and, by emanations suited to whoever is to be tamed,
appears uninterruptedly as wrathful.

Without compassion the fruit is diminished.
When one benefits beings and removes harm,
the fruit is accomplished through purity of one's own mind.

The obscurations of cause and effect
are abandoned far off through the awakening mind.
This is certain to destroy saṃsāra.

The obscurations of the stable and the moving —
when the mind is in equanimity, the antidote
and its adverse condition are vast as space:
this is the spontaneously accomplished final fruit.

For as long as the stain of conceptuality remains,
strive and meditate on awareness.

The preliminary purification of mind through awareness
is held to constitute the stream of the continuum itself.

For one whose mind is stainless
but has been darkened by the stain of conceptuality —
for such a one there is no intellect of abandonment.
One who has the mind of conceptuality is in saṃsāra.

Therefore, those of the Śākya lineage should respectfully attend the applications for cutting off the conceptuality of the nāgas who travel underground, and so forth.

The fifth conceptuality from "Traveling in the Vajra Triple" is now complete.

By the decree of the sovereign lord of supreme power, the king Khri Srong Ide btsan, at the temple of glorious peerless spontaneous accomplishment, this was translated by the Indian preceptor Kumāravajra and the Tibetan translator Ra byed.

Translator's Notes

- The central portion of this text, running from "First is the homage; below that, the fourth syllable adorns the fifth" through to "the first of the third placed at the end," is a technical syllabic-positional cipher for constructing a Tantric seed-syllable mantra. It gives precise orthographic instructions (which vowel sign goes on which consonant, where the half-moon and bindu fall, where the fire seed-syllable RAM is placed, and so on) to spell out a mantra without stating it plainly. Such concealment is standard in Tantric kalpa texts. The passage is rendered faithfully as positional instructions; the underlying mantra is intentionally left undeciphered, as is the convention of the tradition.

The mantra string "PHAṬ HŪṂ NI PĀ DZRA VA RADHA RA VĀLĀṂ NĪ OM" is reproduced from the Tibetan phonetic transliteration; it appears to be a form of the mantra given in reverse order (reading right to left), which matches the instruction immediately before it that the mantra should be recited both forward and reversed. The forward reading would begin OM and conclude PHAṬ.

The phrase rendered "eight-times-two aspects" refers to sixteen characteristic features of a wrathful deity form, a standard iconographic enumeration in this genre.

- The names of the eight directional wrathful deities in the Trailokyavijaya maṇḍala are rendered as closely as the Tibetan permits: "Vajra that Illuminates / Illumines the Three Worlds" renders རྒྱལ་ལོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་ལྷ་མོ་, which likely corresponds to Sanskrit Trailokyamahāvajra or similar. These are technical deity names from the Vajraśekhara / Sarvatathāgatatattvasaṃgraha cycle and exact Sanskrit equivalents vary by redaction.

The passage concludes mid-sentence in the supplied Tibetan; the translation ends accordingly at that natural break.

- The mantra passage is transliterated Sanskrit rendered phonetically in Tibetan script. The transliteration presented here follows the Tibetan syllables as closely as possible and represents a standard dhāraṇī corpus associated with Vajrapāṇi nāga-subjugation texts. Some syllables are ambiguous due to the Tibetan phonetic rendering, and individual readings may vary across witnesses.

The phrase rendered "Nāgarāja Kubera" reflects the Tibetan "klu nor rgyas kyi bu" — literally "son of Nāgarāja Kubera" or "offspring of the nāga Vaiśravaṇa-wealth-king." The identity of this figure is somewhat compressed in the Tibetan, and "progeny of Nāgarāja Kubera" is adopted as the most coherent rendering.

"Padmānābha" is used for the nāga king named "Dab bzang" (literally "good-winged" or "fine-petalled"), which is a conventional epithet; the Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain.

- The names Mugdzin, Gangwa Zang, Norbu Zang, Yangdak Shé, Drokné, Ngatsén, and Picci Kuṇḍali are left in approximate phonetic rendering as they appear to be Tibetan-language epithets or names of specific yakṣa or treasure-guardian beings whose Sanskrit equivalents are either uncertain or not given in this text. The mantras for these beings that follow — Pūrṇabhadra, Mañibhadra, Kubera, Saṃprajñāna, Guhyasthāna, Pāñcika, and Picikuṇḍalī — correspond to well-known yakṣa generals in Vaiśravaṇa's retinue, confirming the context. The phrase "thirty-two syllables of the vai-letter" likely refers to a specific counting of the mantra syllables beginning with the syllable Vai in Vaiśravaṇa's mantra, treated as a technical instruction; this is left as rendered rather than speculated upon further. The passage ends mid-sentence, indicating this is a continuous text and the translation is complete up to the point provided.
- The phrase rendered "the flower of the rose-apple tree" (Skt. jambuka or jambu flower) is a standard simile in which the reflection of a red flower causes a crystal to appear reddish; the point is that non-conceptual awareness appears in wrathful form not through any inherent quality of its own but through the conditioning of beings to be tamed.

The phrase "beneath the vajra earth" at the opening refers to the preceding section of the same text, whose topic heading gave the continuous title. The colophon names the Indian paṇḍita Kumāravajra and the Tibetan translator Ra byed lo tsa ba as collaborators under royal decree of the Tibetan emperor Khri Srong lde btsan, placing the translation firmly in the late eighth century.

The line rendered "Copper and iron are the lama's to bestow" is terse and possibly technical; it may refer to specific grades or types of empowerment objects conferred by the lama, but the text itself does not elaborate.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.